negotiations with North Macedonia, under a deal brokered by France, which was only accepted by the North Macedonian parliament with considerable pain. The good news was that this enabled both North Macedonia and Albania to make a step forward on what will nevertheless be a very long journey towards joining the EU.

At the time of greater enthusiasm for EU enlargement in the early 1990s, Western politicians probably genuinely believed that a big-bang enlargement would impress the public in the West (or perhaps upset people less?). Quite the reverse happened: the sheer scale of the enlargement caused fear among the citizens of EU-15 in an already insecure world of fierce global competition, sluggish economic growth and terrorism. Voters in France and the Netherlands confirmed this in their referenda on the Constitution. In 2006, the Commission openly took the view that further enlargement would have to be put on hold, and it began to apply the criterion of 'integration capacity' which is, in reality, the controversial 'absorption capacity' in a new guise. The fact is that, after 1990, politicians failed to produce a genuinely positive vision of a united Europe and to inform their electorates about the added value of new member states; too many have seen these new states as liabilities. Pressure from sceptical EU countries has only been increasing. Thus in 2020, on the initiative of President Macron, the European Union adopted a revised enlargement methodology, putting more focus on conditions of particular concern (above all the rule of law – a topic that we return to in the second part of the book), a greater role for member states in the process, streamlining of the enlargement process, and, as they promised, more predictability.[26] But none of this sufficed and in 2022 Macron called for a 'European political community',[27] which many understood as delaying the eventual EU membership of not only Ukraine (and Moldova and Georgia), but of Western Balkans hopefuls as well. The new initiative had its official launch in Prague in October 2022, attracting even the participation of post-Brexit UK, with further meetings announced to take place in Moldova, Spain and the UK. We still have to see what will this new initiative actually mean for the Western Balkans.

The new (economic) nationalism, born in Europe after the failure of the European Constitution and further encouraged by the financial crisis of 2008, preceded by the mixed experience of the opening of the labour